

following command gets you the QR Code to the LFY Web page into a PNG file *lfy.png*.

```
gencode -o lfy.png 'http://www.linuxforu.com'
```

Decoding QR codes on the command line is a breeze with the Zbar tool suite. It has two tools: 'zbarcam' and 'zbarimg'. The first activates the webcam to capture your printed QR code (hold the printed QR code steady until you see the green square flash around the code in the camera view), and the second reads PNG images to output the content as text. The following command decodes the QR code in the PNG file *lfy.png*:

```
zbarimg -q lfy.png
```

All three command-line tools enable batch-mode 'qurification' of content or decoding of QR codes.

De facto encoding standards

While the ISO standard mandates the physical encoding standard for the QR Code, there is no formal encoding standard for the various genres of information that need to be encoded: typically biz cards, URLs, geo-locations, email IDs or calendar events. The Japanese company NTT Docomo has devised *de facto* standards to encode various types of information, leading to the SPARQ Code, which is nothing but the QR code that enforces a content encoding standard. Both SPARQ Code and Zxing projects host standards-compliant encoders on their respective websites (see *References*).

Novel uses

While advertisers have been using QR codes for quite some time to increase 'conversion' rates among target audiences, other novel uses have also created an impact. Many museums show QR codes along with their exhibits, making it easy for visitors to dig up more information on them. The QRPedia is another project where a QR code points to a link on a

QRPedia website, which in turn sources information from Wikipedia and customises it for your media consumption device in a choice of languages.

QR codes are a nice way to embellish your resume or business card with. Remember to keep it simple, remain standards-compliant and test your QR code with at least a couple of scanning applications before you deploy it. And lastly, Mom's sage advice: "Don't talk to strangers," and "Look both ways before you cross the road," work well when playing around with QR codes too. Malicious QR codes designed to cause harm are very real, so be cautious while snapping up QR codes that appear in dubious places, from sources you do not trust, or those that prompt you to download apps, send SMSs, or make calls. **END** 

References

- [1] http://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/QR_code
- [2] <http://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/SPARQCode>
- [3] <https://launchpad.net/qcreator> The link to Qcreator page on launchpad.
- [4] <https://launchpad.net/qr-tools/+download> The link to the QtQr download page.
- [5] <http://fukuchi.org/works/qrencode/index.html> En The qrencode page.
- [6] <http://zbar.sourceforge.net/> The zbar tool suite.
- [7] <http://www.sparqcode.com/static/maestro/> SPARQ Code generator.
- [8] <http://zxing.appspot.com/generator/> The Zxing (zebra crossing) project has a standards-compliant QR code generator.
- [9] <http://qrworld.wordpress.com/2011/10/21/qr-codes-viruses-should-we-panic/> This, and the following link, talk about security threats from QR codes.
- [10] <http://mashable.com/2011/10/20/qr-code-security-threat/>

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